

CHURCH

SYNOPSIS

Aziz is a middle-aged homeless man. He is deeply afraid of dying. This fear leaves him caught between what a priest in his congregation tells him and what his only friend, a goat, tells him.

TREATMENT

Aziz, in his late forties, lives in a makeshift shack in the forest. He has lost every relative he had. He spends most of his day helping the church congregation he belongs to. In the evenings he returns to his shack. There he shares his leftover food with his only friend, a goat, and talks with it.

One morning Aziz wakes up in his shack coughing violently. He leaves the shack and pets the goat. He talks to it. The goat doesn't answer. He sets off toward the church. On the way he notices people wearing masks. He arrives at the church. After helping clean it, he hands out food. While eating, he hears people talking about a new illness that has broken out. Those talking say that people who catch it start coughing violently and get worse within a short time. Aziz is frightened. When afternoon comes he goes to see the priest. He tells the priest he is afraid of dying and doesn't want to die. The priest counsels him: he says Aziz has had a hard enough life, and that if he keeps helping he will be happy in the next world. He says death is a blessing for believers. Aziz leaves, unsatisfied. He does the evening cleaning and heads back to his shack. When he arrives he talks to the goat again, about his fear of death. The goat doesn't answer. He goes inside and sleeps.

DAY 1 — THE LANTERN

Aziz wakes up coughing again in the morning. This time he coughs blood. He wipes it off his hands in fear. He leaves the shack. He tells the goat how desperate he is about dying, and that he suspects he is sick. The goat speaks. It grants him a solution. It says the priest's hypocrisy will get him nothing. It says that if he does as it tells him, Aziz can live forever. It gives him a week to complete the solution. On the first day he will find a lantern. On the second day he will find a glass of water. On the third day he will find a handful of soil and a lotus flower. On the fourth day he will find a calendar. On the fifth day he will find a bird feather and a fish bone. On the sixth day he will find a mirror. On the evening of the seventh day he must light a fire and lay all the objects around it. Aziz listens to the goat carefully, taken aback. He accepts what it has said.

He leaves the shack and goes to the church. He does the morning cleaning. After handing out food, he talks to the priest and tells him he has spoken with the goat. The priest mockingly gets angry at him, brushes the matter aside, and talks about how the church needs more help. Aziz leaves the priest. Before leaving the church, he steals a lantern. He returns to the shack and talks to the goat again, describing his exchange with the priest. The goat gets angry. It warns him not to tell anyone about it. Aziz leaves the goat's side and goes into the shack.

DAY 2 — THE LAKE WATER

Aziz wakes up coughing harder. He leaves the shack. He looks around but can't see the goat. He goes back in, takes a glass, and comes out again. Instead of going to the church, he goes to the lake. He watches the lake and fills the glass with its water. He carries it back to the shack without spilling it and hides it. He steps outside and looks around a bit more for the goat. He can't find it. He goes back inside.

DAY 3 — THE SOIL AND THE LOTUS

Aziz wakes up coughing again. There are dark circles under his eyes. He leaves the shack and looks around for the goat once more. He can't see it. Angry at the goat, he sets off toward the church. When he arrives, the priest is angry with him — he demands to know why he stayed away without telling anyone, in a time when the church badly needs help. He mentions that the church has fed him and given him a place to stay in the shack. He accuses him of laziness. Aziz can't offer a real answer and starts cleaning. He cleans the church garden. While eating, he notices people keeping their distance because he is coughing. During the evening cleaning he takes a handful of soil from the church garden. He sets off toward the shack. While wondering how he will find a lotus flower, he notices one left in a corner deep in the forest. He picks it up off the ground. He wonders how it got there. He continues on. When he arrives, he finds the goat waiting in front of the shack. It tells him he needs to try harder — that without its help he will amount to nothing. Aziz grows more afraid. He goes inside.

DAY 4 — THE CALENDAR

Aziz wakes up in even worse shape. He tears a page from the calendar inside the shack. He leaves and talks to the goat, telling it about the priest blaming him. The goat counsels him: "Witch hunts have as much to do with witches as you have to do with being blamed for living the life you chose. Which is: nothing at all. People simply love creating scapegoats. It comforts them. If it weren't you, it would be someone else. The world never runs out of witches — they just change shape." Aziz goes back inside.

DAY 5 — THE FEATHER AND THE FISH BONE

Aziz wakes up coughing, utterly weak. He leaves the shack. It is midday. He wonders if it's too late for everything. He searches the forest for a bird feather and finds one. Then he asks a fisherman for a cleaned fish bone. The fisherman looks at him, taken aback, and hands it over. Aziz returns to the shack.

DAY 6 — THE MIRROR

Aziz barely manages to gather the energy to get out of bed. He leaves the shack. Keeping his distance from people, he searches for a mirror. He comes to the front of a barbershop and sees a small mirror inside. He greets the barber. While waiting his turn, the barber sets a small hand mirror down on the table beside him. The barber and a customer talk about the new illness. Aziz steals the mirror without anyone noticing and leaves before his turn comes. He returns to the shack.

DAY 7 — THE FIRE

Aziz wakes up but can't get out of bed for a while. He is sweating. He falls back asleep and mutters in his sleep. He wakes again to the goat's voice. It tells him the time has come, that he must go outside

and finish the preparations. Aziz gets up. He notices brushwood gathered in front of the shack. Following the goat's commands, he arranges the objects around it. He lights the fire. He first throws in the lantern. Then he pours the glass of lake water over the flames. The fire flares up. Then he throws in the handful of soil and the lotus flower. He watches the fire grow. As he watches, he has trouble hearing the goat's directions over it. The goat warns him sharply and orders him to go on. In turn, Aziz throws in the calendar page, the bird feather, and the fish bone. When it is the mirror's turn, he looks into it carefully. He doesn't recognize himself. He realizes he is on his deathbed, and thinks that the goat has been using him too. He begins to cry. The goat, furious, keeps raining down directions. Aziz talks about how everyone has tried to use him his whole life, how alone he is, used even by his only friend. With his last strength he smashes the mirror and passes out. The priest comes out of the forest, his face full of worry. Amid the goat's bleating, he looks down at Aziz's body together with the goat.